

ALL THE LANDS HAVE FALLEN PROSTRATE BENEATH HIS SANDALS FOR ETERNITY

THE TEMPLES OF ABU SIMBEL (c. 1264 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Pharaonic Egypt

BEFORE

c. 3050 BCE Narmer unifies the kingdoms of Upper and Lower Egypt.

c. 2680 BCE Khufu begins construction of the Great Pyramid in Giza—it is the largest pyramid in history.

c. 1480 BCE Thutmose III conquers Syria, extending his empire as far as the Euphrates.

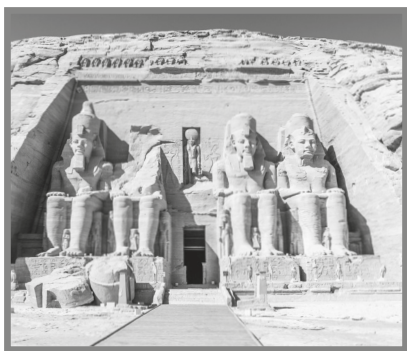
AFTER

c. 1160 BCE Ramses III fights off invasions of Egypt by Libyans and raiding tribes known as the Sea People.

c. 1085 BCE Collapse of the New Kingdom; Egypt is divided with Libyan rulers in the north and Theban priest-kings ruling in the south.

7th century BCE Egypt is invaded by Assyrians and then Persians.

Around 1264 BCE, the Egyptian pharaoh Ramses II (c. 1278–1237 BCE) had two mighty temples hewn out of the cliffs on the west bank of the Nile in southern Egypt. The entrance was guarded by four vast statues of the pharaoh, seated in glory and wearing the symbols of divine kingship, including the double crown that signified his authority



The magnificent temple complex at Abu Simbel was, remarkably, moved 656 ft (200 m) inland and 213 ft (65 m) higher up in 1964–1968 to rescue it from the rising waters of the Nile during the construction of the High Aswan Dam.

over Upper and Lower Egypt. The temples were designed to signify and embody the unique status, ambition, and power of the ancient Egyptian pharaohs.

The pharaonic tradition

Ramses II inherited a tradition that was already very ancient: about 1,800 years earlier, King Narmer (called Menes by the ancient Greek historian Herodotus) first unified the kingdoms of the Upper (southern) and Lower (northern) Nile. Narmer's deeds were recorded on a stone palette, which was recovered from a temple at Hierakonpolis in the 19th century and provides one of the earliest known depictions of an Egyptian king.